7.3 St. Thomas Aquinas (1224/1225-1274)



Learning Objectives

1. To study about the Political thought of ***St. Thomas Aquinas***
2. This will help to understand ***Aquinas***'s concept of law
3. To gain knowledge about ***Acquinas***'s ideas on Origin of State, Functions of the State, Classification of Government, Classification of Laws, Relations between Church and the State.

Life And Times

In Western Europe the thirteenth Century was regarded as the golden age of western philosophy. Catholicism emerged as the universal religion in Western Europe. Eventually ***Aristotle***'s Politics, re-emerged during the thirteenth century. Sharp differences arose between ***Aristotle***'s secular views and Augustine's religious ideas on sin, the Fall, and political society which were accepted by the church and as a binding doctrine. However, some philosophers faced the challenge of how to accommodate their theological views and a set of secular political assumptions, which finally resulted in the reconciliation of two different ways of understanding the world. They finally succeeded by terming politics and political theorizing as a trivial pursuit vis-à-vis people's higher calling of getting right with God. ***St. Thomas*** Aquinas was the greatest among these Christian theologians who architected this major philosophical triumph.

St. Thomas Aquinas (1224 or 1225-1274) was born in the family castle of Roccasecca, north of Naples. His father was Landulf of Aquino, who headed a minor branch of an important land owning family and his mother was Theodora Rossi belonging to Neapolitan Carracciolo family.

Aquinas' Works

In the nineteenth century, Pope Luis XIII declared that the philosophical system which Aquinas founded to be official Catholic theology, which made reading his works not only important for Catholics but also for those who sought a more than surface understanding of that branch of Christianity. Aquinas works included commentaries that stem from his theological design. Some of his important works include, (i) Summa Contra Gentiles (1264), (iii) Summa Theologica (1274) and (iv) On Kingship.

Aquinas' Thought

Summa Contra Gentiles

It has often been said that Aquinas wrote the Summa Contra Gentiles (SCG) as a manual or text book designed to be used by the Dominican missionaries working in Spain where Islam was then a force to be reckoned with by Christians. The SCG is evidently an apologetic work, since it defends a series of Christian beliefs that were under criticisms or that could come under potential criticisms.

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